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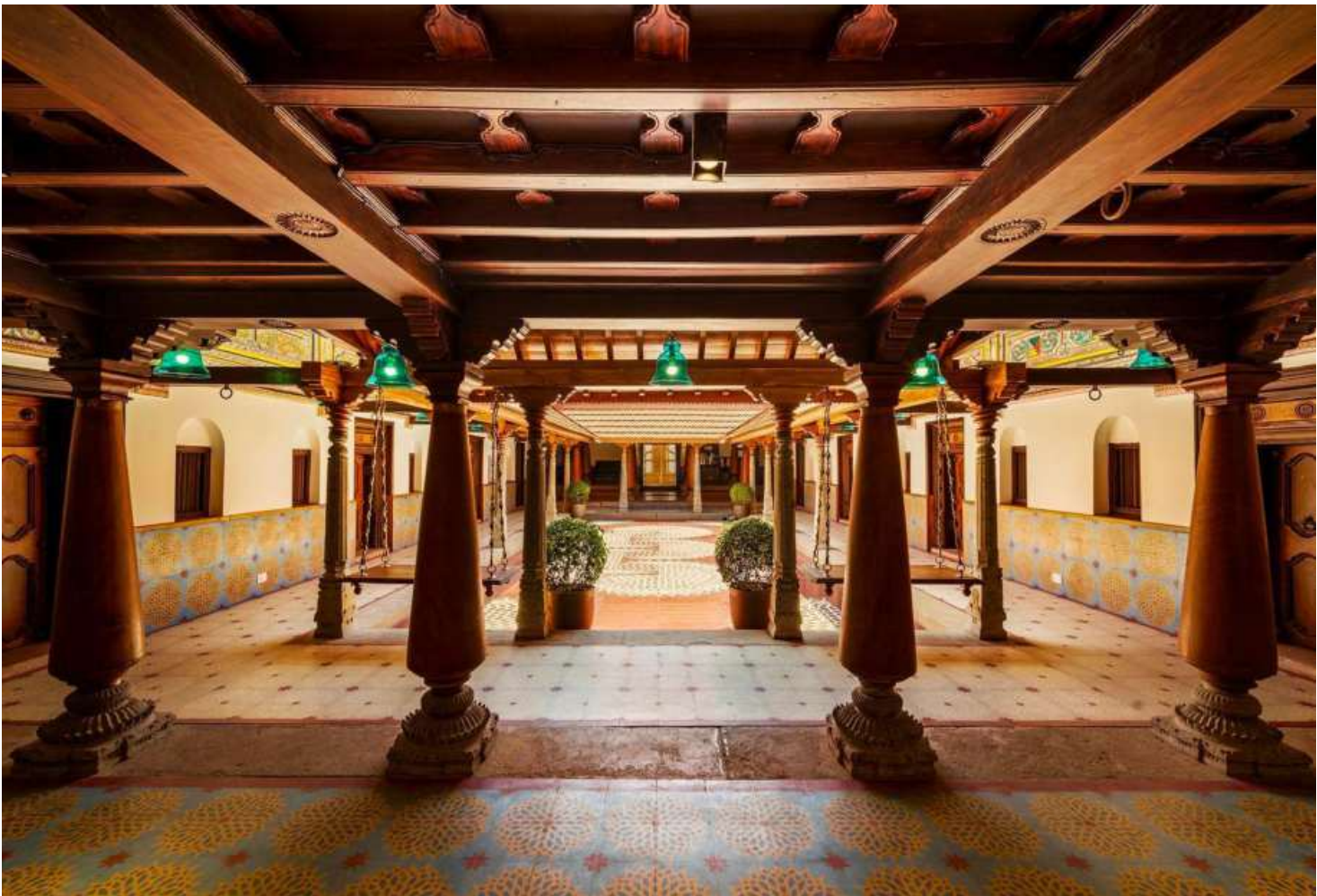
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The Lotus Palace by The Park opened last year in Kanadukathan, in a 230-year-old mansion. Traditional Chettinad houses feature carved Burmese teak pillars, stained glass windows, crystal chandeliers and Athangudi tiles. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

The aesthetic of the Chettiar is travelling across the world. But as interest expands from food to design and architecture, the question is whether this revival will help sustain what remains

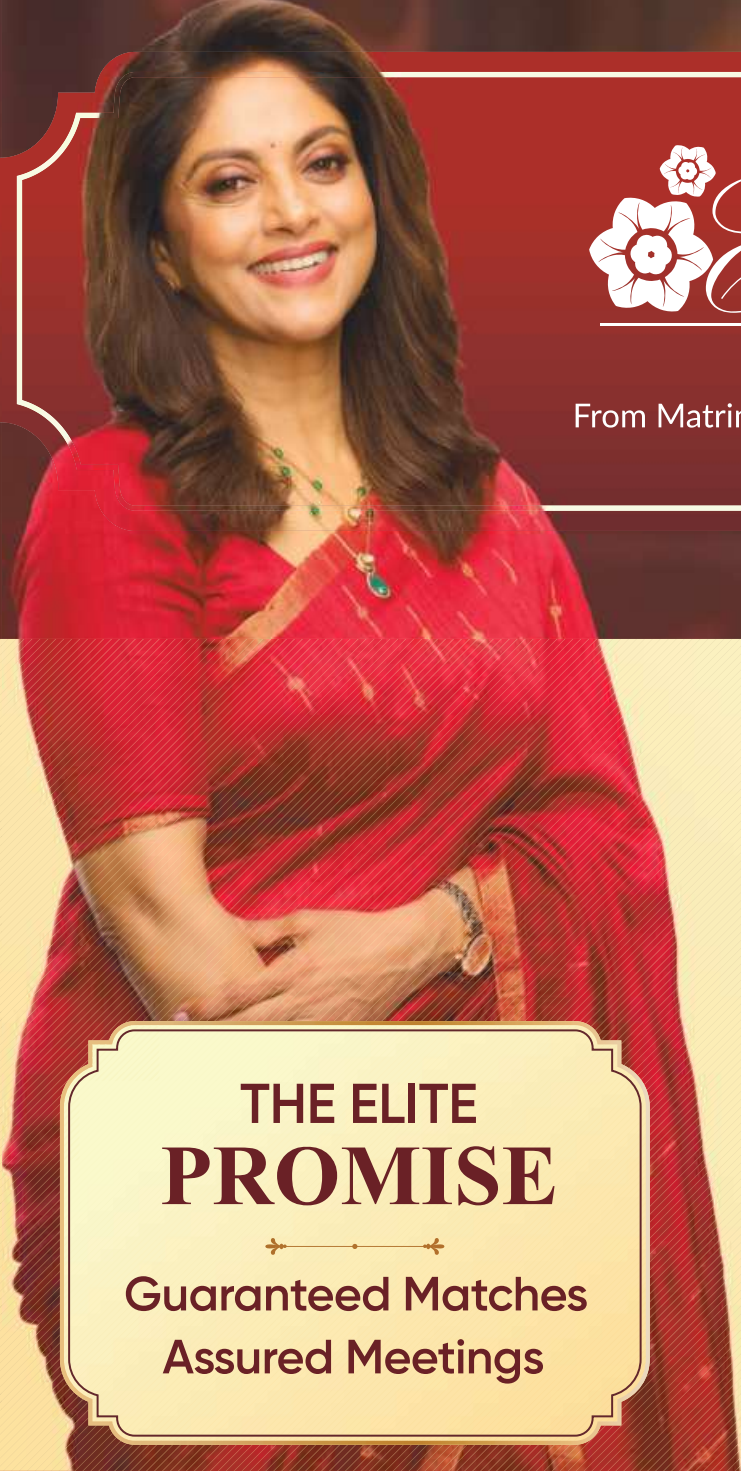
CHETTINAD'S PARADOX OF FAME

Shonali Muthalaly
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Chettinad is undergoing a revival. Its mansions are paying the price. As travellers, architects and designers discover the region's unique aesthetic via festivals and curated holidays, luxury homes and hotels across the country are increasingly being outfitted with Burmese teak doors, granite pillars, vintage tiles and even carved wooden roofs retrieved from century-old mansions. "Entire houses are being

cannibalised," says Chennai-based architect Sujatha Shankar. "Wares from these homes fuel a thriving antique market, drawing buyers in India and abroad." Comprising 75 villages (Karaikudi being the largest town and commercial hub), spread over about 600 square miles, the region is home to the Nattukottai Chettiar, who built houses here between the end of the 18th century and the mid-20th century.

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Preeti Zachariah
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Steffie, the unlikely protagonist of Siân Hughes' darkly funny new novel, *No Such Thing as Monday* (Picador India), emerged from a writing workshop game. "There would be all these jobs in the middle of the table, and I had to pick one; I always picked the laundress," says the Cheshire-based teacher and writer, whose debut novel, *Pearl*, was longlisted for the Booker Prize in 2023.

Hughes found herself going back to this character over and over again, continuing to write in the voice of this laundress, who "has been with me for quite a long time". She began her exploration of Steffie, a deeply flawed, self-destructive woman working at a dry cleaners, by asking her a series of questions: "Why are you so obsessed with getting the stain out of this garment? Why do you feel so impure inside? What has happened to you that makes you feel so unworthy?"

The more she conversed with this character, "a bit overweight... in her 50s... [who] swears all the time... [is] really bad-tempered and difficult to get on with", the more she found herself wanting to inhabit and explore Steffie's story, although she did worry that she'd be "the only person on this planet who would love this woman".

But Hughes' fears are clearly unfounded. For all of Steffie's problems, she is a compelling character with a wry sense of humour and scrappy resilience. As a reader, you can't help but root for her, even when her self-destructive streak makes you throw your arms up in despair, something Hughes struggled with, too. Edited excerpts from an interview:

Question: No Such Thing as Monday shares uncanny similarities with Pearl in the themes it explores, such as the long-term impact of childhood trauma, isolation and grief, the unreliability of memory and mental illness. What draws you to these themes?

Answer: It is really difficult as a writer to understand what your common themes are because you tune in to different narrators, and you think you've gone somewhere new. It's only later that you realise that there are so many things in common with them. Both my narrators, Marianne [protagonist of *Pearl*] and Steffie, have very serious long-term damage, but that only occurred to me afterwards. And yes, this is a massive thread of interest to me: what happens to your memory, to your relationship with your own memories, when some sort of serious trauma has disrupted your relationship with yourself. With Steffie, I wanted to think



IN CONVERSATION

THE INVISIBLE WOMAN

An abrasive heroine navigating trauma and survival is at the centre of Siân Hughes' new novel

about growing up in a situation where you are constantly in denial. I remember something my cousin, who's very clever, said to me: that denial is the strongest human emotion because it's the only thing that can wipe out your primary data, removing that access to what is in your head. What we are trying to explore in Steffie is that, because of this, she doesn't have a strong sense of her personal narrative, the ability to see the future, to believe in her own

storyline, to plan, and not to behave in a self-destructive way.

Q: Could you tell us more about Steffie's origins?

A: The idea of the invisible middle-aged woman was really important to me in this book. I worked for quite a long time with an organisation called The Choir with No Name, a charity here in the U.K., that runs choirs for people affected by homelessness. I ended up understanding a lot more about

Siân Hughes was on the 2023 Booker longlist for her novel *Pearl*. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



homelessness through that job.

When we say homelessness, a lot of the time, we think of people sleeping rough with no roof. But statistically speaking, it's a tiny, tiny minority. Many homeless people just live in very insecure, poor housing, which they often have no right to. With someone begging on the street or living in a tent by the roadside, the crisis is visible. But there's also a vast sea of invisible suffering and insecurity above that, and Steffie is part of that society.

Many aspects of her story emerged from work that I've done in small charities, ones that do not attract a lot of funding since their causes are not "cute", unlike those that work with puppies, kittens or babies. I wanted to open up people's eyes to those hidden corners in cities where somebody's doing very good work, helping the most vulnerable people, but they're just doing it very quietly, very unassumingly.

Q: Both No Such Thing as Monday and Pearl are inspired by the 14th-century anonymous 'Gawain poet'. Can you tell us more?

A: It all comes from the same medieval manuscript, which contains three poems: 'Pearl', 'Patience'; and 'Cleanness'. I do really love those poems; they are insanely structured, ridiculously tied up in knots and obey so many rules that you can't help but be awestruck by them. And I've always wanted to write a response to all three of them. This is my response to the one called 'Cleanness' or 'Purity', which is nobody's favourite poem. It's a bit of a sort of rambling mess of a long poem, all about preparing your soul for heaven and washing yourself clean of sin.

But in fact, it's all about laundry, really, the thing that Steffie gets from her mother, who also earns a living as a laundress. I wanted that really powerful, resilient female thread. Of how her work, the thing she brings from her mother, is what keeps her going and constantly rescues her.

Amid the faultlines

This powerful story with a simple, familiar premise proves yet again that Daniyal Mueenuddin is a gifted writer

Sheila Kumar

The focal point of Daniyal Mueenuddin's novel *This Is Where the Serpent Lives* is deceptively simple in its linked concepts. Greed, overarching ambition, not knowing "one's place" in life (Pakistani society, in this case), the courage required to step out of line, and the inevitable nemesis that comes to those who do step out of line. The one major takeaway, so pertinent to us who live in Epsteinish times: power acts as a super-shield, protecting all under its umbrella.

Mueenuddin follows his Pulitzer-nominated debut *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders* (2009) with this ticking metronome of a story. To and fro it swings inexorably, never once letting the reader's attention drift. The arch of the metronome introduces several characters to us, and we know all their lives will be intertwined at some point or the other.

There is Bayazid, the lumbering giant big on loyalty above all else. We stay long enough with his story, meeting his mentor, his friends, the love of his life, to start wondering if he's the protagonist. Eventually, we see him as a trusted aide and chauffeur to industrialist and landowner Hisham Atar, he of old money and power.

Then the focus shifts smoothly to the U.S.-educated Hisham and his elegant, sharp-as-a-pin wife, Shahnaz. We meet their socialite friends, and see just how the upper crust in Pakistan lives: houses in London, only the best Champagne and caviar served at their tables, game shoots, networking like mad, drugs done casually – a conveniently lax bar where morals are concerned. It could be the wealthy anywhere in the world.



This is Where the Serpent Lives
Daniyal Mueenuddin
Penguin
₹799

Hisham has a farmhouse and land at an estate called Ranmal Mohra, which he visits on and off with his wife, with his friends, driven there by Yazid. Of course, the estate manager is stashing away Hisham's money – giving an up-and-comer ideas.

Hidden ambitions

The story then moves to the up-and-comer Mohammed Saqib, son of the gardener at Ranmal Mohra, introduced to Hisham by Yazid, working his way up slowly and steadily, first a staff member at Hisham's Lahore house, much favoured by Shahnaz, then becoming a farm manager at Ranmal Mohra. The story settles, tells us

about Saqib's secret ambitions, his intelligently calibrated handling of his employers, his love for Gazala whose Hindu roots cast a shadow over her family.

It doesn't take us long to realise that here is the main peg: Saqib, whose diligence, hard work, careful planning and quick improvisation, is but a cover for his personal ambitions, his desire to snatch as much as he can from the somewhat naïve and trusting Hisham.

When the tale reaches its cataclysmic conclusion, we aren't sure whether to sympathise with Saqib or silently acknowledge that this is the way the wheel turns everywhere, that restoring the status quo is of primary importance.

Pakistan's history from Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's time onwards is touched upon, but lightly. All the characters get their defining details, the author acting like a pointillist artist.

This is a story with a simple core, powerfully told. Daniyal Mueenuddin is indeed a gifted writer.

The reviewer is an author, journalist and manuscript editor based in Bengaluru.

Kheer to catastrophe

These short stories blend the ordinary with the surreal

Sharmistha Jha

Having read and loved Maithreyi Karnoor's debut novel *Sylvia*, which weaves together fragmented stories of belonging and loss, I was eager to dive into her new book, *Gooday Nagar*. This collection of 10 absorbing stories begins with the lives of ordinary people and ends with a thrilling post-apocalyptic finale.

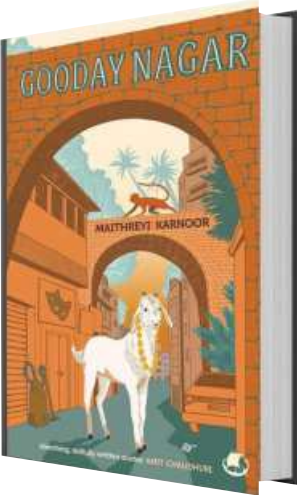
In the title story 'Gooday Nagar', a

vacuum cleaner salesman from Delhi arrives in a small town inhabited by an armless ghost. The salesman awakens the latent desire for consumerism in an otherwise content group of townspeople. In another story, a woman believes that her *guruji* has turned into a goat. Traditional beliefs collide with modern sensibilities, offering a vivid portrait of the contemporary Indian village – one that resists any easy romanticisation of rural life.

Food plays an important role in the collection. The residents of

Gooday Nagar are mostly rigid vegetarians, and the stories are rich with references to dishes like *kheer*, *puri-sabzi*, *jowar rotis*, *dhokla* and *khakhra*. The appearance of a meat dish signals that the story is either set outside Gooday Nagar or that the characters occupy the margins of the city.

In 'Mapmaker, Mapmaker, Make Me a Map', a girl with vitiligo watches the white patches on her dark skin grow, convinced that her skin is going to turn completely white, transforming her into a



Gooday Nagar
Maithreyi Karnoor
Tranquebar
₹499

foreigner. She begins to fantasise about going abroad. The story also examines the quiet devastation of the COVID-19 pandemic and how it impacted students who could not afford gadgets to keep up with online classrooms.

Free from anxieties

The narratives in this anthology explore interpersonal relationships, young romance, infidelity and the pull of unspoken desires. Each story is better than the last, but it is the final one that takes the cake, quite literally.

People wake up in a post-apocalyptic world to the shocking discovery that others have inexplicably turned into cake. Even the machines seem sentient – buses and planes move of their own

accord, carrying passengers to unknown destinations. There are no drivers or other people in sight.

In this uncanny landscape – overrun with wild greenery in the absence of humans, and where solitude has become the norm – two characters begin to build a life beyond the trappings of the old order, with its dead-end jobs, taxes and anxieties.

Writing in the first person here, Karnoor crafts an absurd plotline that is both amusing and eerie. Yet, rather than inspiring dread, this altered world offers a strange, almost soothing relief from the anxieties of modern life.

The independent reviewer and editor is based in New Delhi.

BROWSER

The Memory of Shadows

Mijing Gwra Basumatary
Rupa
₹295

Drawing inspiration from the myths and oral storytelling traditions of his native village in Assam, the author-researcher puts together a sensorial collection of tales about forest spirits, village healers, and whispering bamboo groves.



The Things We Never Say

Elizabeth Strout
Penguin
₹1,304 [ebook]

The Pulitzer-winning bestselling author of the Olive Kitteridge and Lucy Barton series returns with a standalone novel about life amid a loneliness epidemic. The story is told through a 57-year-old high school teacher's perspective.



Before I Knew I Loved You

Toshikazu Kawaguchi
Picador
₹550

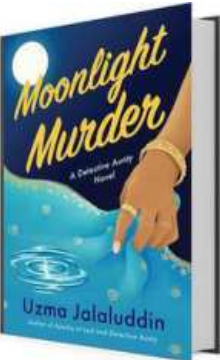
What would you do if you could go back in time, is the question at the heart of this popular Japanese series. A 'slow-burn' bestseller since the first book, *Before the Coffee Gets Cold*, readers love them for their warm and emotional core.

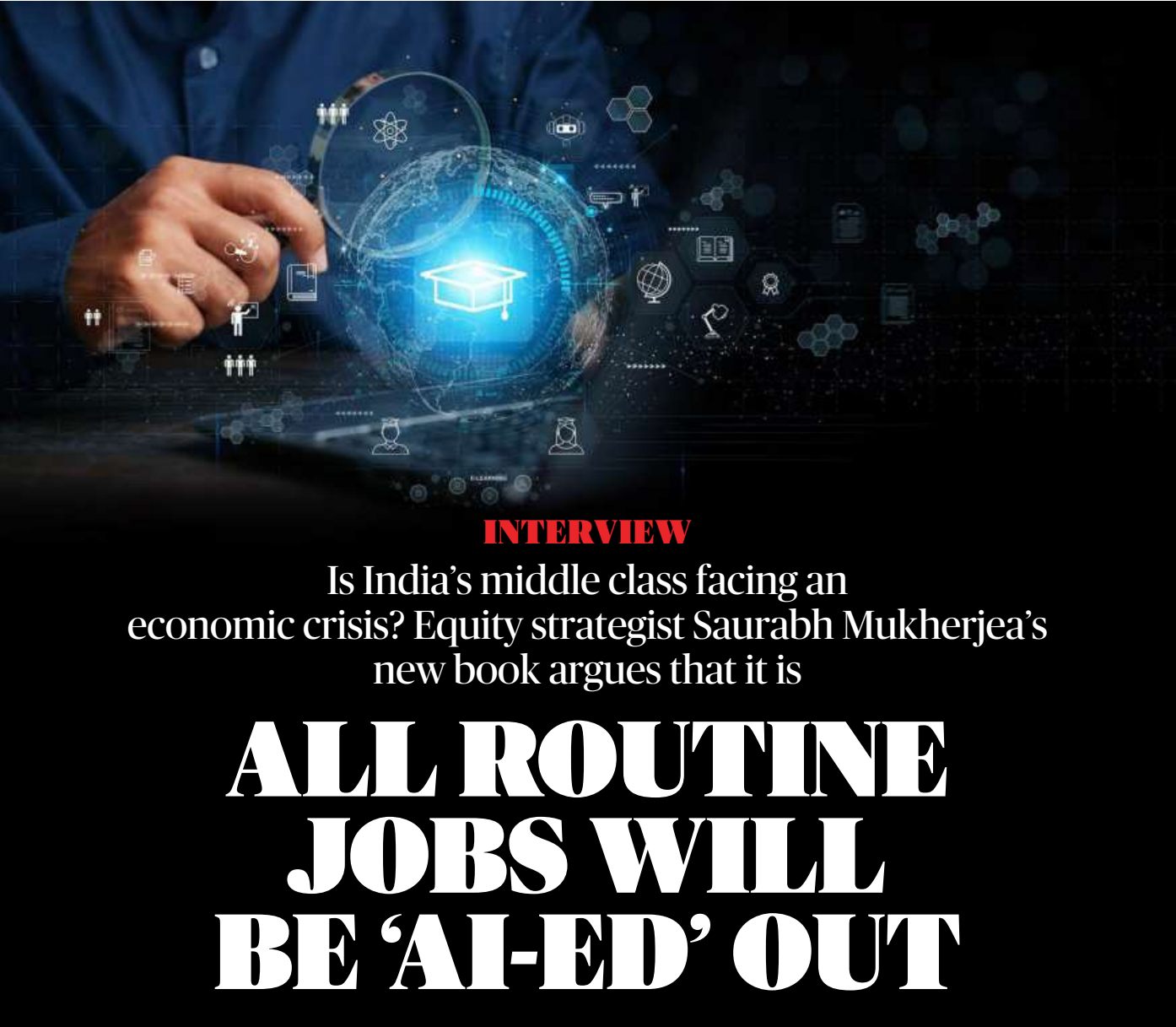


Moonlight Murder

Uzma Jalaluddin
Harper Perennial
₹984 [ebook]

The second instalment in the Detective Aunty series returns to Toronto, where protagonist Kausar Khan once raised her family, stirring buried memories and trauma. Jalaluddin is best known for her debut novel *Ayesha at Last*, a contemporary retelling of *Pride and Prejudice*.





INTERVIEW

Is India's middle class facing an economic crisis? Equity strategist Saurabh Mukherjea's new book argues that it is

ALL ROUTINE JOBS WILL BE 'AI-ED' OUT

G. Sampath
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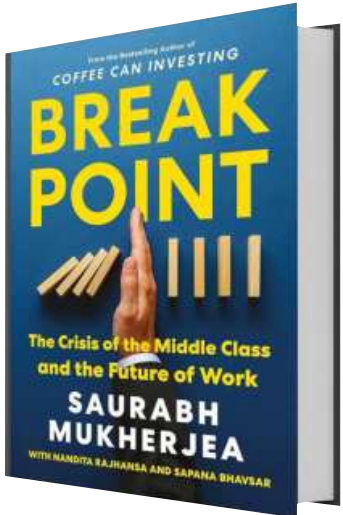
In his new book, *Breakpoint: The Crisis of the Middle Class and the Future of Work* (Juggernaut), equity strategist Saurabh Mukherjea, along with Nandita Rajhansa and Sapana Bhavsar, argue that the middle class in India is being pushed to the edge due to three factors – Artificial Intelligence (AI) disruption, wage stagnation and ballooning household debt. In this interview, he explains what this section can do to adapt to the new future of work. Edited excerpts:

Question: When I first saw your book, I thought it was about tennis. Why *'Breakpoint'*?
Answer: There are three different layers to the title. One is the tennis sense of the word, where our point was that the Indian middle class has been at the receiving end of much punishment – technological disruption, real wages getting compressed, and so on. But at the same time, the rise of AI could also lead to the creation of 100 million jobs in India over the next five years. Therefore, this point in history gives the Indian middle class a chance to turn the tide on the setbacks they have suffered over the last 10-20 years.

The second interpretation is the one where, on the cover image, the hand comes down. We used the hand because the Indian middle class has been under pressure. We have plenty of data to show that real income has been crushed in the last decade or so. White-collar job growth has all but disappeared. Sectors such as call centres and IT services are badly affected. In economics, we use the term 'breakpoint' to describe a point where an adverse trend turns. And more specifically, the breakpoint here refers to the notion that middle-class India can go to university, graduate with a good degree, get a safe job, get promoted over 20 years. That consumption-driven era is coming to an end.

The third layer of interpretation is around debt. Middle-class debt has exploded in India over the last six years. Reserve Bank of India data show that if you exclude mortgages, household debt has tripled in the last six years or so. So, we are pointing to the fact that we are at breaking point in terms of how much debt is being loaded onto middle-class households.

Q: Should the middle class stop expecting that a good education will lead to a good job? Is that paradigm over?
A: Yes, that covenant is broken. We are



looking at 30-40 per cent unemployment rates in the year of graduation even for IIT students. You can go to Harvard or Oxford if you want, but university education is giving you diminishing returns. The unemployment rate for graduates is around 30 per cent. The unemployment rate for unlettered people is 3 per cent. In other words, the rate of unemployment for graduates is 10 times of what it is for those without literacy.

When I travel to small-town India, SME (small and medium enterprises) owners tell me they are telling their children to skip going to university as it is a waste of time. I found that remarkable.

Q: What would you say to someone from the middle class who is worried about the future of their children?
A: You touched a raw nerve. I have got two teenaged children and I spend a lot of time worrying about them. Here are three things my wife and I are trying. The first is to teach them frugality. I run a small firm of my own. We don't own a car. We try to save a fair bit and invest a fair bit of money so that we can buy self-insurance for ourselves and use that money to finance our children's education as well. We try to set aside two years of emergency funds in fixed deposits at any point in time so that in case something happened to me or to my company, the family would be taken care of for two years.

The second aspect is that routine work – be it in investment or

journalism or any other sector – will be eliminated by AI. So, do something which is not routine. For example, selling, whether it is a fridge or investment products, or convincing people to go on luxury holidays – those jobs will remain. Jobs which involve an emotional connection, which involve uncertainty, which involve the counterparties trusting each other, building a relationship – those jobs tend to be less easy to 'AI out'.

The third piece of advice is to bear in mind that in a developing country such as ours, there will always be plenty of work. It's just that very little of that would be available in the structured format of a job. So, if you're an entrepreneurial person, there is plenty of work. It could involve training school kids to create large language models, or helping investors plan their personal finances, or teaching people Bharatanatyam. I am confident that in the years ahead there will be plenty of people from non-mercantile communities who will build successful businesses in India.



Equity strategist Saurabh Mukherjea



Scan the QR code to watch Saurabh Mukherjea in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

Mannu Bhandari's quiet revolt

Her autobiography, translated from the Hindi by Poonam Saxena, explores how she balanced domestic constraints and literary ambition

Sneha Pathak

My introduction to Mannu Bhandari – writer, teacher, and playwright – was through the kohled-eyed, sari-clad Deepa, the protagonist of Basu Chatterjee's 1974 film *Rajnigandha*, based on Bhandari's short story *Yahi Sach Hai*. Years later, when I read the story, I was once again struck by her near-flawless depiction of the intricate matters of the heart and her direct, simple portrayal of a woman's complex emotions. Simplicity and candour have always been the hallmarks of Bhandari's writing, reflected in her autobiography *Ek Kahani Yah Bhi* (2007), translated from the Hindi by Poonam Saxena as *This Too Is a Story*.

At its heart, *This Too Is a Story* is the account of a woman writing despite domestic constraints and gendered expectations. Yet her work, which was a core part of her being, could never get the first priority. She had to find time for it while taking care of her daughter and her home besides managing her job. Whatever she wrote was "not at their cost, but in the middle of fulfilling these responsibilities."

Born in Madhya Pradesh in 1931, Bhandari spent her childhood in Ajmer, Rajasthan. The place and its people left an indelible mark on her; many of the characters in her stories are based on the people she knew while growing up. Her father, both a liberal and traditionalist, insisted that Bhandari be educated, but never treated his wife with dignity.

This pattern later echoed in her marriage to Rajendra Yadav, another stalwart of Hindi literature, from whom she separated after 35 years. It is not surprising that a considerable portion of the autobiography, including the Afterword (originally written as a stinging rejoinder to Yadav's autobiography *Mud Mudke Dekhta Hoon*), recounts the experiences of her marriage. Her hopes that marrying another writer would mean entering an equal creative partnership were dashed early on when Yadav insisted on living a parallel life under the same roof. Bhandari was also tasked with earning a living and managing every aspect of their household, while Yadav escaped these responsibilities with the "trump card of 'I have to write'...always in his hand". Numerous incidents throughout the narrative portray Yadav as "a male ego steeped in feudal ways."

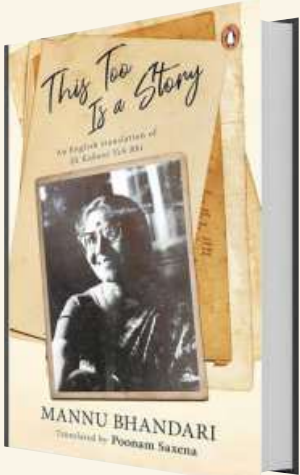
However, Bhandari is not all bitter. She gracefully accepts that Yadav encouraged her to write and gave titles to several of her short stories such as *Vidushak*. She also acknowledges his role in helping her complete her novel *Aapka Bunty*, reassuring her that their daughter was doing fine while Bhandari, staying in a hostel to finish the book, was riddled with guilt. But it would be a disservice to read *This Too Is a Story* merely as an account of her marriage. Bhandari describes the literary atmosphere of the

1960s and '70s, including its politics and the ego clashes among male writers such as Yadav and Mohan Rakesh. Their shifting friendships and mutual attempts to bring each other down come through unfiltered to the reader. She also recollects the kindness of friends, family, acquaintances, and strangers that carried her through the darkest phases of her life.

Besides, Bhandari attempts to analyse the causes of her own inferiority complex, which made her hesitant to own her success. She also reflects on why it took her 35 years to break off with Yadav, and defends herself against allegations of being "interested in commercial writing" during her television work.

At the same time, her autobiography also offers a glimpse into her theory and process of writing through discussions of some of her stories. These, coupled with her reflections on writing, literary trends, and socio-political events, including India's struggle for independence, the Emergency, and the 1984 riots, make the book more wide-ranging than a writer's account of her domestic life and creative process.

In her detailed and comprehensive Introduction, Saxena does an admirable job of placing the autobiography as well as



This Too Is a Story
Mannu Bhandari, trs Poonam Saxena
Ebury Press
₹599

Bhandari's life and writing in perspective. This is particularly helpful for those not closely acquainted with the canon of Hindi literature. Her translation captures the simplicity of prose found in Bhandari's writing. Saxena has also translated Yadav's autobiography, which further provides her a unique vantage point on their shared history.

Bhandari wrote more than 50 stories and three novels (one in collaboration with Yadav), but a vein of diffidence, tinged with regret at her inability to write much in her later years, runs through her autobiography. The number might seem modest, but not when seen in the light of the conditions under which she wrote. For a writer who never quite had a room of her own, this output is no mean feat.

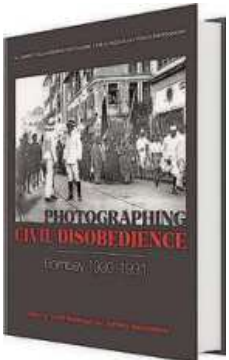
The reviewer is an independent writer and translator based in Pune.



Photographing Civil Disobedience: Bombay 1930-1931

Ed. Avrati Bhatnagar and Sumathi Ramaswamy
Mapin Publishing
₹1,950

The album presents 245 black-and-white images of streets alive with anti-colonial protests. It offers insights into the forces that shaped disobedient action and nationalist politics in 1930s Bombay.



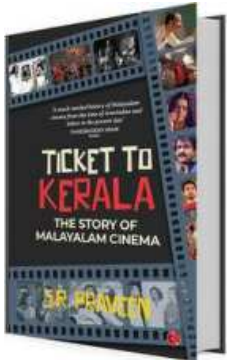
James Baldwin: A Love Story

Nicholas Boggs
Bloomsbury
₹1,999
Boggs rediscovered and co-edited a new edition of James Baldwin's out-of-print collaboration with the French artist Yoran Cazac. This is the first major biography of Baldwin in three decades, drawing on newly uncovered archival material and original research and interviews.



Ticket to Kerala: The Story of Malayalam Cinema

S.R. Praveen
Rupa
₹495
Through this book, Praveen intends to introduce Malayalam cinema to an audience outside Kerala, moving beyond its post-2020 spotlight. He shifts the focus to its deeper roots and evolution over time and reveals its true origins.



Beneath the Smile

Karthik Chandrasekar
Writers Corner Publication
₹500
Chandrasekar is writer, model, disability activist and banker. He was diagnosed with quadriplegic cerebral palsy at birth. In this book, he goes beyond surface-level optimism to reveal the silent battles and unseen struggles that often remain invisible to the world.



CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

The successful mercantile community travelled across South and Southeast Asia, and poured the money they made into lavish mansions, spanning 20,000 sq.ft. to 40,000 sq.ft.

At its peak, Chettinad had about 15,000 mansions. Today, fewer than 10,000 remain, of which only about 10% are maintained or occupied. Photographer and author Amar Ramesh, who has been documenting the mansions for the past decade, and brought out *Mogappu* (2023), a book documenting their 108 grand entrances, estimates that the number of remaining homes is closer to 7,000.

"There are two types of destruction," he says. "Some houses are falling apart because there is no maintenance. One of my favourite *mogappus*, a colonial-style verandah, collapsed recently. Then there are those being torn down, though that is not recent. A lot of houses were wiped out between 1938 and 2010."

Business of dismantling Higher prices, however, are now accelerating the decline. At the Karaikudi Antique Market, Raghavendra, whose father started dealing in Chettinad's artefacts 40 years ago, says one or two mansions come down every month, after which the pillars and wood are shipped across the world. He adds that buyers now come from France, Sweden, the Czech Republic, and England. Lokesh Kumar S. of



Chennai-based Antek Woods says a door recently sold for ₹1 crore. "When it comes to antiques, the price depends on how much the buyer wants the piece," he says, adding that social media and WhatsApp now help Karaikudi's carpenters, carvers and locals access buyers globally.

According to sources, as the community now understands the value of these homes, one member of the family tends to buy out the rest (each house is often owned by multiple cousins, so it can have 40 to 50 claimants). They then sell different parts to dealers, which is more profitable, especially because there is growing demand from buyers abroad. The rosewood and teakwood are repurposed for furniture, and the usually untouched doweries of enamel ware, brassware and glasses are sold separately.

On Instagram, for instance, one post advertises 12 stone pillars on sale for ₹2,000 to ₹5,000 each, plus loading and shipping charges. Today, Kathiravan, manager at the Chettinad heritage hotel, The Lotus Palace by the Park – who has been tracking land prices – says it

costs ₹7 crore-₹10 crore to buy a mansion, depending on its location and size. However, he adds that the community prefers not to sell to outsiders, which could explain why public sale listings are hard to find. Restoration can cost about ₹15 crore, says architect



CHETTINAD'S PARADOX OF FAME



Shankar, adding that a single room can cost a couple of crores. "Some people want to do only the front," she says. "But more families are updating now because the next generation may not be equipped to restore these homes, and craftsmen are fewer."

Shankar, adding that a single room can cost a couple of crores. "Some people want to do only the front," she says. "But more families are updating now because the next generation may not be equipped to restore these homes, and craftsmen are fewer."



Can hotels save Chettinad? Restoration has been magnified by the push to save Chettinad, spearheaded by the Chettiar community, historians, and a small but committed group of hoteliers and architects, driving repair and adaptive reuse. When The Bangala was opened in 1999 by Meenakshi Meyyappan – who is credited with putting Chettinad on the tourist map – it drew attention to the Chettiar's

banana leaf lunches and warm hospitality. The Lotus Palace opened last year in Kanadukathan, in a 230-year-old mansion that spans more than 16,500 sq.ft. Renovation took four-and-a-half years because the group focused on using original material and local labour. It has just 15 rooms and suites. At Chettinad Palace, built between 1902 and 1912, proprietor A. Chandramoli,



Festivals in focus

The Chettinad Culture and Heritage Festival, spearheaded by Meenakshi Meyyappan and The Bangala (pictured above), now in its sixth edition, draws national and international attention. It sells out quickly every year. Priced between ₹1.5 lakh and ₹2 lakh this year, it will be held from September 18 to 21, and will showcase the region via concerts, talks and tours. The Park also runs two annual festivals: Kalai, focused on architecture, and Suvai, an immersive culinary holiday. Since there are a limited number of rooms available, these festivals are necessarily small, with between 30 and 150 people. But what they lack in size they make up for in influence, as the six major properties in the region join forces, drawing a focused guest list. "The Chettinad festival was not meant to sell a hotel," says Meyyappan, explaining why they work as a group. "It was meant to sell Chettinad as a destination."



are undeterred. "The value of such a project lies in its positioning rather than scale," she says, adding that they attract "guests who are looking for more than just a hotel room."

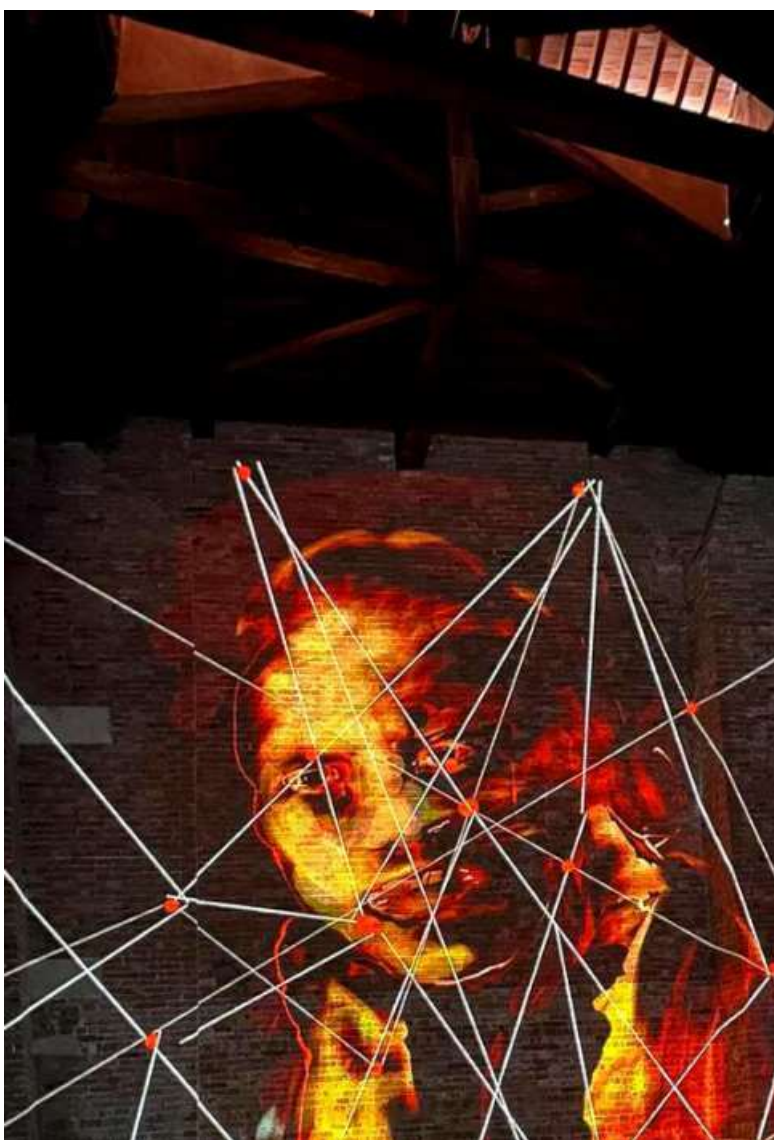
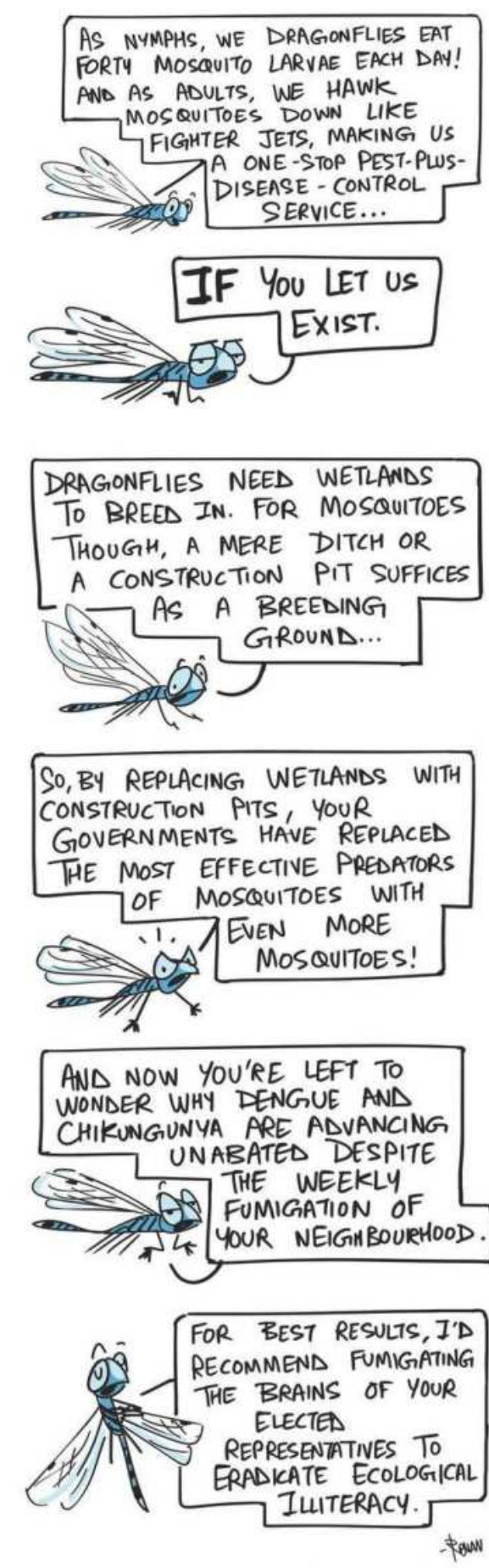
Locals are now enthusiastic about tying up with hotels, often with an agreement in place so they can continue to have their weddings and family functions there. Tourism also brings fresh opportunities: though hotel rooms are still limited, there has been a rise in mansions being opened up. Visitors can explore CVCT House and its dramatic 240 wooden *mandapams* carved with 240 *yalis*, for just ₹50. Homes are also opened up to film crews, with prices ranging from ₹1,000 for a one-hour photo shoot to about ₹25,000 a day for video.

Movies and shows shot here draw more visitors to the region.



GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Gautami Reddy

At 180, Nalini Malani remains one of India's most unsparing artists and feminists. A fierce critic of war, power and capital for decades, Malani has consistently pointed to a world shaped by an often violent, largely unchecked masculinity, in which the feminine is diminished.

Her practice has responded directly to the fault lines of the state, from India's emergence as a nuclear power and the long shadow of Partition to episodes of communal violence and ongoing global conflict. At a moment marked by crisis and its uneven human cost, she brings that inquiry to a major collateral exhibition presented by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art at the 61st Venice Biennale this month.

Since her early years in 1960s Bombay, Malani has returned to myth as a way of exposing how

these structures repeat across time. Drawing on Greek figures such as Cassandra, Medea and Electra, she has reworked these stories across drawing, painting and video, staging them in what she calls "animation chambers": powerful, immersive environments in which thousands of hand-drawn and digital images flicker, overlap and surround the viewer, accompanied by sound. A pioneer of digital media in her generation, she uses this form to reach a wider public.

Her latest work, *Of Woman Born*, is an animation chamber composed of 30,000 iPad drawings, installed inside the Magazzini del Sale, a 15th-century salt warehouse within the Venice Biennale's exhibition circuit. Drawing on the Greek myth of Orestes, who murders his mother and her lover to avenge his father but is spared punishment by Athena, it examines the underlying logic of a patriarchal system in which violence against

women is legitimised.

As the museum notes, "For Nalini Malani, the present moment resonates with this myth, where wars are waged in the name of self-defence and those who perpetrate violence frequently remain unaccountable. Through this parallel, the work urges a rethinking of geopolitical boundaries and foregrounds the agency of women who bear the brunt of global conflict."

Ahead of the opening, Malani speaks about power, violence, myth, and the role of the artist in the hard, necessary work of imagining change.

Question: What compelled you to make an animation on this scale?

Answer: What we are witnessing globally is unbearable, a turn towards the hypermasculine. When you watch what is unfolding in Sudan, Ukraine, Gaza, Lebanon, Iran, you feel an extreme sense of helplessness. And anger. You feel it in your



body. You clench your fists. You feel you have to do something. That is how the drawings began, from a place of urgency.

Q: Why does myth remain a necessary language for you?
A: The structure of injustice is very old. In the myth of Orestes, which dates back to the 5th century BCE, he kills his mother and is forgiven by Athena, the goddess of wisdom and justice. That forgiveness becomes law.

In the play, Athena establishes a



If the world is to move forward, not just technologically but meaningfully, we must look at it through new eyes. And those must be, in some way, the eyes of a woman

NALINI MALANI

court, the Areopagus, and introduces a system of voting. A jury of citizens deliberates. There are two urns, and each vote is cast and counted. It is presented as the beginning of democracy. But when the vote is tied, Athena, born from Zeus's head and having never known a mother, casts the deciding vote in favour of Orestes. This marked a crucial evolution from the archaic, private system of retaliatory blood vengeance (revenge) to an institutionalised, state-based justice (for civic justice). But this was at the cost of erasing the women, and we are still living under that law.

Q: Where do you locate the deeper roots of the violence we are witnessing today?

A: I believe it lies in something often ignored: violence against women, and perhaps more deeply, violence against the feminine within all of us, whether one is a man or a woman. Women philosophers like Adrienne Rich, Judith Butler and Hélène Cixous inspire me, and I use that thinking to make sense of what's happening now. If the world is to move forward, not just technologically but meaningfully, we must look at it through new eyes. And those must be, in some way, the eyes of a woman.

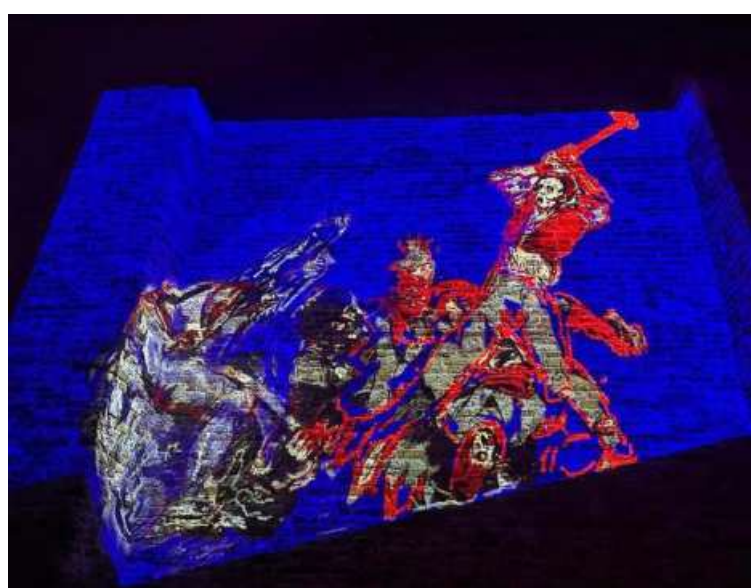
Q: How did the site inform the experience?

A: We've transformed the Magazzini del Sale into an animation chamber. I didn't want to alter the space, so I worked with projection. It feels like cave painting, but animated. Outside the chamber, The Skipping Girl, who has followed me across the years in my drawings and animations, now appears on posters, banners and *vaporetto* [Venetian waterbus] signage, guiding visitors to the work. She is a symbol of joy, but also something close to hysteria, skipping almost too hard, as a way of pushing back against the horror around her.

Of Woman Born is on view from May 9 to November 22, as a collateral event of the Venice Biennale.

The writer specialises in reporting on art, design and architecture.

Statement at the salt warehouse (Clockwise from left) Elements from Nalini Malani's *Of Woman Born* (9-channel iPad Animation Chamber); and the artist.



IN CONVERSATION

NALINI MALANI'S VENICE RECKONING

In her new work at the Biennale, the artist examines the patriarchal order in which violence against women is legitimised



BINGE WATCH

So boys will be boys?

On the manosphere's prime time slot and toxic influencers who are shaping a new generation

depictions, both terrifying for very different reasons. *Adolescence* deep dives into the psyche of a troubled young boy who has started believing he's entitled to the bodies of young women. What makes him believe so? The tonnes of online content he consumes from Andrew Tate-like creators.

The Boys kicks things up a notch and asks the viewer: what if the world's most powerful superhero was also an irredeemable misogynist knee-deep in incel-culture talking points? Enter principal antagonist Homelander (Antony Starr), the most terrifying TV villain in recent memory. A virtually

invulnerable being draped in a stars-and-stripes cape, he embodies the manufactured victimhood that white American men, especially, have the manosphere to thank for. Homelander is a rapist who espouses the subjugation of women. His twisted Oedipal obsession with breast milk gets explained in some of the more disturbing scenes.

Cultural legitimacy

As an Indian viewer, I could draw solace in the fact that the misogyny in Indian movies and shows isn't typically this extreme. But view the landscape in its entirety and you see the

nakshatra [birth star] of the owners, and it is a formula in six steps. When you walk in, you feel that energy. It is not just the embellishments that everyone is responding to. It is also the rhythm."

Holding on

The Athangudi tiles, however, can be easily incorporated into apartments, restaurants and hotels, and the demand has encouraged a rise in skilled workers. S. Palaniappan, production manager at Chettinad Tiles, estimates that there are about 500 factories across Karaikudi today. At his factory, workers make about 600 tiles a day, which are shipped globally, he says, pointing to boxes packed to be sent to Singapore and Malaysia.

Murugappan Shanmugam of the 200-year-old S.M.R House in Konapet explains why there are families that will keep holding on to their homes, despite the fact that maintaining them can cost between ₹1 lakh and ₹5 lakh a month. "We do it for sentimental reasons, as well as for heritage value," he says. "I spent summer holidays there with my grandparents, and saw my sisters' marriages take place in that house. It is filled with memories, everything from playing in the courtyard and sleeping under the open sky, to attending village and temple festivals, and watching Tamil movies in 'tent *kottai*' aka touring talkies."

In Kadiyapatti, an elderly Chettiar lady sitting in her darkened, silent mansion echoes this. "I came here when I was 25, and we were four families living together. Now, I sleep alone in this house, and I am not afraid. Our ancestors watch over me. We are determined to keep it. You can never buy something like this again."

Rising interest

Driven in part by social media and festivals, hotels have seen an increase in guests. Senthil Kumar Bheeman says occupancy at Chidambara Vilas, which has 25 rooms, was about 40% before the pandemic. It is now around 65% on average, with most guests coming during the cooler months of October to March, when the occupancy rises to 85%. "Chettinad is also becoming a popular wedding destination for niche, intimate functions," he adds.



More families are updating now because the next generation may not be equipped to restore these homes, and craftsmen [with the skills required to do the work] are fewer

SUJATHA SHANKAR Architect

regression. Male comedians such as Kapil Sharma and Zakir Khan – dominant by any standards in the last 7-8 years – have made careers out of gendered and misogynistic jokes. Khan has since shed his self-styled "sahit laundaa" (tough guy) persona in favour of a more family-oriented style, but that doesn't erase his earlier comedy specials, all of which are still consumed by young men across the country. *Comedy Nights With Kapil* was tailor-made for middle-aged men laughing, drinking and exchanging "wife jokes". Recently, a Tamil YouTube asked actress Gouri Vishan a highly inappropriate question about her weight – the audacity and entitlement don't just come about in a vacuum.

The cultural legitimacy we allow these relatively milder forms of manosphere content have emboldened the Indian entertainment industry, which has produced far more brazen, misogynistic and incel-inspired films such as *Arjun Reddy*, *Kabir Singh* and *Animal*. Bollywood producers are desperately trying to recreate the success of last year's *Saiyaara*, the story of an angry incel transforming after falling in love. He becomes a softer, kinder, sensitive man. By no means a great or even a competently-made film, *Saiyaara* is the only Bollywood film in recent memory that had the temerity to even wonder what young women want.

Amid talks of the 'male loneliness epidemic' (a term the media rarely tires of), have none of the alleged victims ever considered how manosphere podcasts are making them lonelier? The Myron Gaines and Sneaks of the world are counting on these boys' social isolation to keep their own cash registers ringing. True "abundance mindset", then, is a simple yet diversified life, with family and friends (and animals and birds, perhaps), with vulnerabilities and weaknesses that are accepted and cared for, not "life-hacked" or "looksmaxxed" out of existence.

Aditya Mani Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.

Azera Parveen Rahman

When you take into account that houseboat construction in Kashmir has been suspended for decades, the Delhi Development Authority’s proposed ₹4-crore houseboat plan (as a permanent fixture at Baansera Park in Delhi) underscores a striking irony. Meanwhile, a British Museum-funded project has been documenting the techniques and oral histories of Kashmir’s last-remaining artisans. The research, now complete, is ready for submission this month.

Nearly four decades ago, the Jammu & Kashmir government banned the construction of new *doongas* (houseboats) to curb unregulated growth and pollution in Dal Lake. Since then, many master craftsmen have died, leaving behind only a few practitioners such as Ghulam Ahmad Najar. “I am bound to these boats; there is nothing else I know,” says the boatmaker from Bandipora.

Funded by the British Museum’s Endangered Material Knowledge Programme, the project that began in October 2024 has drawn attention to the craftsmen themselves. Last year, in Srinagar, in the presence of the director of J&K’s Department of Handicrafts, master craftsmen were felicitated, with the promise that hull builders, who also repair houseboats, will be included in the list of Kashmiri craftspeople, making them eligible for government schemes, loans, and other support.

Retracing the legacy

According to popular perception,



SPOTLIGHT

KASHMIR’S LAST HOUSEBOAT MAKERS

A British Museum-funded research documents the dying craft, years after construction ban

the British are credited for introducing houseboats in the Kashmir valley. But Sayali Athale and architect Anto Gloren, the researchers leading the project, say the craft is at least “400-500 years old” and is an intrinsic part of the region’s cultural heritage. “These floating dwellings have been around since the time of the Mughals, and have been mentioned in *Ain-e-Akbari* and *Jahangir-Nama*,” Athale says.

Houseboats have been a way of daily life in Kashmir. In the 1920s-30s, adds Athale, *doongas* were used to travel from Srinagar to Anantnag, a road distance of 60 km today. Master craftsman Abdul

Khaliq Najar says, “In the earlier times, until around 1947, a type of boat called *bahast* was made in order to navigate the canals throughout the city. It would transport rice, wheat flour, firewood.” Once roads were built, *bahasts* faded away.

The documentation project has brought to the forefront voices of the four remaining master craftsmen, called *wasta* in Kashmiri, and their vast repository of traditional knowledge. Among them, Nazir Ahmed Kawdari died in his late 50s this January, leaving behind Abdul Khaliq Najar, and brothers Ghulam Ahmed Najar, 67,

and Mohammad Subhan Najar, 65. “While all their sons have, at some point, assisted them in the process [of boat-making], whether they will be able to build such boats themselves remains to be seen,” Gloren says.

Challenges along the way

In 1988, the construction of new houseboats was stopped. “Before this, thousands of houseboats could be found on Dal and Nigeen lakes and the Jhelum river. Today, fewer than 750 remain,” says Gloren.

Houseboat-making is a tedious process. The making of the hull alone takes five to six months. The

Ceremony of the boat’s hull being pushed into Nigeen Lake, Srinagar, November 2024. (COURTESY ANTO GLOREN & SAYALI ATHALE)

researchers, however, could witness the craft’s detailing during the rebuilding work permitted after the 2022 Nigeen Lake fire gutted seven houseboats. “One of the highlights of this documentation was the ceremony of pushing the completed hull into the water before commencement of the superstructure construction. If boats are constructed in the Dal or Nigeen boatyard, the sluice gates are used to move the hull into the lake, so this ceremony is rare,” Athale says. “Since this houseboat was constructed on the lake’s edge, they moved it in the traditional way with almost a hundred community members pushing the 120 ft.-long hull into the waters.”

In 2023, a new houseboat policy provided for minor repairs to existing *doongas* and houseboats, albeit with no mention of the techniques or materials to be used. The houseboats are traditionally made with Deodar wood but owing to a lack of forest timber now, they are being repaired using wood from



In the earlier times, until around 1947, a type of boat called *bahast* was made in order to navigate the canals throughout the city. It would transport rice, wheat flour and firewood

ABDUL KHALIQ NAJAR Master craftsman

old buildings and bridges. While this timber is of high quality and seasoned through decades of use, they are of different sizes, forcing a change in construction technique, thereby affecting the boats’ quality. “The biggest change is that since only smaller pieces of wood are available now, there are more joints in the boat,” Athale says. The *pasch*, the longest structural part on either side of the hull that holds the boat together, would earlier be one piece. Now it is made as three pieces and joined. “Since the houseboats are now tethered to the lake’s edges and not expected to travel far, the large number of joints isn’t much of a problem,” she adds.

A glimmer of hope

The master craftsmen have been building smaller boats – for sand-dredging, fishing, transport, and *shikaras* – and, since the last two years, they have been rebuilding the charred houseboats. This is their only means of livelihood, says Abdul Khaliq Najar, even though the younger generation has sought employment elsewhere. “Among the sons, some own grocery stores, pharmacies, one is in the police, and some work as carpenters,” Athale says.

But Ghulam Ahmad Najar is hopeful: that with the government’s recent felicitation, their knowledge will not be lost. “The data collected will be available in an open-access platform. And the community will have access to the methods and techniques employed by their predecessors, for posterity,” concludes Gloren.

The writer is an independent journalist based in Delhi.

GOREN BRIDGE

No way out

Both vulnerable. East deals

Bob Jones

South won the opening heart lead - an obvious singleton - with dummy’s ace. He had an inescapable heart loser, so he needed to dispose of his club loser. He could do that several ways. He could take the club finesse through West, he could take the diamond finesse through East, or he could take a ruffing finesse for the

king of diamonds through West. Which one should he choose? South found a line of play that let him avoid making that choice. South drew trumps in three rounds and led a diamond to his ace. He then led his remaining heart and played low from dummy. East won but found himself end-played in three suits. If he led a heart, either low or the ace, dummy’s queen of hearts would become a trick. A diamond lead would

build a diamond trick for declarer regardless of who held the king. A club into dummy was an obvious disaster. East chose a low diamond, so South shed a club from dummy on his winning diamond and eventually ruffed his club loser in dummy. Nicely played! It is not often that a difficult problem has such an elegant solution. It’s a great feeling for a bridge player when you come up with one.

Hand layout showing North, South, West, and East cards and suits. Includes a bidding table and a note about the opening lead.

Bidding table and a note about the opening lead.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has May 3 ever given us?



Charles Tennant experimented with multiple chemicals to achieve the effect and eventually discovered the use of calcium hypochlorite. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

On May 3, 1374 BCE (approx.), Mesopotamian astronomers at Ugarit recorded a spectacular phenomenon: “On the day of the new moon, in the month of Hiyar, the Sun was put to shame and went down in the daytime, with Mars in attendance.” What unique event were they describing?

Born on May 3, 1768, Charles Tennant grew up in a family of weavers in Scotland. One task required cloth to be kept in stale urine for long periods. He experimented with multiple chemicals to achieve the effect and eventually discovered the use of calcium hypochlorite. By what name is this better known?

Born on May 3, 1892, George Paget Thomson was a physicist. His father, J.J. Thomson, won the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1906 for showing that an entity was a particle. George won the same in 1937 for showing it was a wave. What fundamental entity earned them both Nobel Prizes?

On May 3, 1913, *Raja Harishchandra*, the first full-length Indian feature film, was released. Who was the director and producer who marked the beginning of the Indian film industry with this film?

Born on May 3, 1919, Pete Seeger was an American singer-songwriter whose activism in support of international

disarmament and civil rights had a global effect. He was partly responsible for popularising a song that is a staple at protests. What song has been translated into *Hum Honge Kaamyab*?

Born on May 3, 1959, Ben Elton is an English screenwriter who is known for comedy and satire on British TV. His most unusual hit was co-written with a Mr. Atkinson and features almost no dialogue at all. Which show follows the adventures of a man and his teddy bear?

On May 3, 1978, the first unsolicited bulk commercial email was sent by Gary Thuerk of Digital Equipment Corporation to every ARPANET address on the U.S. West Coast (393 recipients).

What are such messages now called?

On May 3, 1997, chess grandmaster Garry Kasparov began a six-game match, eventually losing 3½-2½. This was a historical first and, later, a documentary film titled *Game Over* was made on it. Who was his opponent?

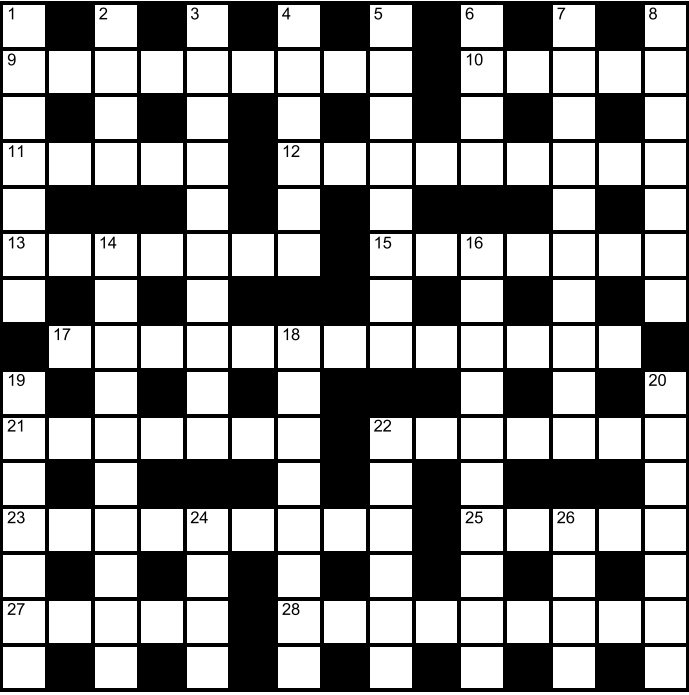
On May 3, 2000, the sport of geocaching began. It involves players locating a cache placed at specific coordinates. With over 3.4 million active caches across 191 countries, what key technology does it rely on?

The U.N. declared May 3 a day to raise awareness of, and remind governments of their duty to respect and uphold, the right to freedom of expression under Article 19 of the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Especially for those who collect and disseminate information. What is this day called?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

Answers section listing the solutions to the quiz questions.

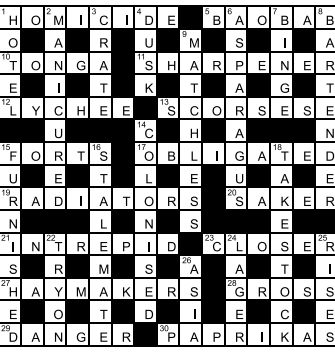
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 54 (Set by Vidwan)



- Across 9 Listen in, the first lady has a small mention (9)
- 10 Go on about English being meanest (5)
- 11 Cry about adopting India colour (5)
- 12 Fool hosting a short form of artistic work/period drama on TV (4,5)
- 13 So return could be sponsored (7)
- 15 Good and right to take responsibility as adult (7)
- 17 I've innocence! No convoluted nuisance! (13)
- 21 Perhaps only chap relinquishing power to become happy (7)
- 22 Scoring century in gentleman's game and yet a bit shaky (7)
- 23 Local clubs McCartney regularly goes to dehydrate (9)
- 25 Stir fear over fine (5)
- 27 Cause devastation with clubs discarded by amateur (5)
- 28 Fan crossing line to watch engaging royal consume grass in excess (9)

- Down 1 Cryptic callers' crypts (7)
- 2 Oddly you've a large cricket ground (4)
- 3 Go back into shop coyly, perhaps for study of personality (10)
- 4 A forced kind of despair (6)
- 5 Small request by German peacekeepers for painting tool (5,3)

SOLUTION NO. 53



Finding purchase
in the supermarket
of everyday life

Simarjit Sidhu
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The other day, during a routine visit to a supermarket, I picked up a trolley at the entrance, as we all do almost mechanically. Before I could begin selecting groceries, a quiet thought arose in my mind, turning an ordinary moment into a deeper reflection on life.

A supermarket, I realised, is not very different from the journey of our existence.

We enter with an empty trolley, much like we enter this world with a body entrusted to us. As we move through the aisles, we begin to fill it. Some items are chosen out of necessity, the essentials of living. Others are picked out of curiosity or attraction, appealing yet not truly needed. And some are added absent-mindedly, without thought, neither needed nor desired.

Is this not how we live our lives? Throughout our journey, we perform countless actions. Some are thoughtful and necessary, aligned with duty and responsibility. Others arise from fleeting desires or distractions. Many occur without awareness in habitual and often meaningless actions.

Yet as we approach the exit, a moment of reckoning awaits. At the billing counter, every item is accounted for. Nothing is overlooked. Each choice must be paid for, whether careful or careless. Even the empty trolley is checked to ensure nothing escapes. So, it is with life. Before our own exit, there comes a time of accounting, when every action is weighed. Nothing we have gathered can be ignored or set aside.

In the store, we know we are under watch. This awareness shapes our conduct. Yet in life, we often forget that a higher awareness exists, before which all actions unfold. Unlike any surveillance camera, it never fails. Still, there is comfort in this realisation. We are free to choose what we place in our trolley. We can pause, reconsider, and put things back before reaching the counter.

That day, I completed my shopping as usual, paid my bill, and returned home. Yet I carried something more valuable than groceries, a reminder that life is not only about collecting, but about choosing with awareness and accepting the account that follows.

What we place in our trolley today determines what we must answer for tomorrow.

And perhaps the real wisdom lies in learning to pause more often, to question our impulses, and to recognise that not every attractive choice deserves a place in our trolley. A mindful life is a lighter one, with fewer regrets at the final counter.

If we choose well, the bill we face will not burden us, but affirm the life we have lived.



N. Rama Rao
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Transfers of Governors, judges, and other senior functionaries often hit the headlines, some even raising eyebrows. Sweeping transfers of election-related officials ahead of polls get wide publicity. But what goes unnoticed by the public are the hundreds of transfers and postings that take place in government and private establishments day in and day out.

A transfer is typically understood as moving an employee to a new location as distinct from inter- or intra-departmental shifting within the same place. It is done for reasons such as promotion, filling vacancies, or balancing the workforce, to mention a few.

Employees rarely welcome a transfer due to the significant disruption it causes to their personal and professional lives – from family upheavals such as changing schools for children and surrendering the ration card to financial strain that includes losing the advance rent paid. Not surprisingly, a young bank official who had several domestic responsibilities to discharge opted to continue as a clerk to avoid being transferred as an officer. Transfer policies in government vary from department to department and from post to post. While higher officers are transferred by the issuance of Government Orders, departmental heads are vested with powers to move their staff, according to administrative exigencies. Private and public sector enterprises have their own respective rules.

Transfers are used as a tool to promote organisational efficiency, irrespective of individual considerations which result in unequal transfer rates within the same office or department. An uncle of mine who was serving the State

Far beyond the desk

Transfers are a necessary inconvenience that have an impact on the personal and professional lives of employees

Revenue Department was known for his troubleshooting ability. Recalling bittersweet memories of his service days, he once said that on many occasions, before unpacking his baggage at the place to which he had been transferred, he would be asked to report in another station with the result that he could not even change his clothes before undertaking the onward journey. As against this, one of his colleagues who made himself indispensable at his desk in the same department was not moved at all, thanks to his bosses who found ways and means to retain him.

Vicious weapon

On the downside, transfers at times transform from a standard administrative procedure into a “vicious weapon” used by bosses to punish and control their staff. A frequently cited instance is the transfer of an honest IAS officer 53 times in about 30 years of his service, as he refused to yield to criminal-political nexus.

Against this background, any transfer to a difficult place in public interest is looked upon as a punishment. During my service as the head of a division in a Union government department, I often encountered several cases of refusal by staff under my charge to get transferred to Northeast India, Jammu and Kashmir, or Andaman Islands, though they were liable for transfer anywhere in India according to the recruitment rules. The person concerned would try to move heaven

and earth to get the order cancelled with the result that the posts in these areas remained unfilled, thereby stalling development activities.

There is the bright side of transfer too. Some employees are eager to move to any location, as well. Looking beyond the immediate challenges of a transfer, these people welcome it as it provides a much-needed change with additional allowances, and chances of career advancement, besides creating an opportunity to experience a new culture.

The general rule is that an employee should accept a transfer even if it be to a place not preferred, and report there. If an official's attempts to cancel his transfer order come a cropper, he will approach a politician or a union leader for help. Courts rarely interfere with transfer orders which fall within the administrative domain of the employer. However, they intervene when evidence proves a transfer order was passed solely to punish an employee or was in retaliation for union activities or for raising legitimate grievances.

The prevailing tendency in certain quarters to view an official transfer to “sensitive” or “unfavourable” stations as punitive in nature and unusual, should be discouraged by the government. It is imperative that persons holding high offices who receive orders of transfer to such places, should send a powerful signal by accepting the orders rather than trying to circumvent them by resigning or applying for long leave.

Vijaya Bharat
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While reminiscing about issues in communication, it is often said that “in those days mobile phones were not there”. Now, the world over, be it in deep Africa or posh Europe, almost everyone holds a mobile phone. If this be an index of progress, India is far advanced, with the urban-rural divide getting narrow. UPI payments are being favoured in all cities and even in some villages. It makes transactions in small denominations easy while buying *jhal muri* on a train or peanuts from a roadside vendor.

In the 1980s, on my first trip to Dubai, I wondered why people walking on the road were talking to themselves. It took me a while to realise that they were, in fact, talking over their mobile phones. I felt silly, just like the dapper senior in a television commercial a couple of decades later when mobile phones came to India. He believed that a lovely woman was inviting him to dinner, until she took her mobile phone away from her ear.

ISTOCK/ GETTY IMAGES



The heartbreak visible on his face was enhanced by the tinkling of shattering glass.

From a young age

Recently, I saw a toddler in a pram with a mobile phone strategically clipped in front. The baby with a pacifier in the mouth was looking wide-eyed at cartoons while the mother was pushing the pram and talking on her mobile. A mother had come to a restaurant with her three

young children. She was feeding them in turns, even as each child was glued to a device. My husband, a surgeon, narrated an incident. A 10-year old girl awaiting surgery refused to let go of the phone while the nurse wanted to take her inside the operation theatre. The patient's father, a villager, told helplessly that she would not part with the phone and whatever injection required to induce anaesthesia could

be given with her holding her mobile and that was done. On regaining consciousness after surgery, the child searched for her mobile.

Vice-like grip

Currently, we are in a vice-like grip of mobile phones and constant scrolling. Even world leaders attending a funeral have been unable to remain solemn and were caught taking selfies. It is common to see youngsters posing in dangerous locations and at precipitous heights for a photo that will get “likes”.

Despite the warnings on signboards, almost all drivers talk while driving, be it on a two-wheeler with a mobile phone clutched between a tilted head and a shoulder, or while navigating a car on busy roads. While attending functions or watching television, people find it difficult to let go of their mobile phones. It is like a genie that has come out of the magic lamp. Everyone seems to be possessed to make the genie constantly work at the cost of overloading the brain and losing direct inter-personal communication. When family and friends gather to meet, instead of conversation with eye contact, everyone seems

to be glued to their phones; such snubbing has a name now – phubbing.

The overindulgence in mobile phones points to a need for damage control.

Many countries and a few Indian States have imposed restrictions on the use of mobile phones by children. Methods of digital de-stress are being discussed. Instances of young people preferring to die rather than live without their mobile phones made me think of an outrageous solution – an automatic periodic down regulation of the mobile phone to its basic function of just receiving and making calls. Such periods will help to defog the brain, and get the eyes to refocus on distant objects, neck to straighten and shoulders to roll back. But it is not fair to blame technology for our lack of self-control. The world has moved far into high tech and convenient communication. Technology will keep evolving because that is what humans do, become better and more advanced. The challenge is to maintain our sanity and take care of our mental health. That responsibility solely lies with the user clutching the phone, not to fall “into its clutches”.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

A plastic-free world may seem unattainable, yet the current crisis — overflowing landfills, oceanic pollution and microplastics — demands urgent change. (‘The plastic blame game’; April 26) Significant reduction in plastic usage is achievable through strict regulation, adoption of biodegradable alternatives and responsible consumer behaviour. The way forward lies not in convenience, but in conscious choice and sustainable living.

N.S. Reddy

I appreciate the multi-stakeholder approach the writer takes to both the problem and the proposed solutions. Featuring sustainable and plastic-free businesses can provide other organisations with viable options to consider.

Senthil Kumar Rajasekaran

The article rightly shifts focus from individual guilt to corporate accountability. The sachet economy and dismantling of reuse infrastructure are structural decisions, not consumer choices. Mandating recyclable material standards and restricting multilayer packaging would address the problem where it actually originates — in design, not disposal.

A. Myilsami

Redefining the future

I'm a high school student and I've been researching resurrection biology for a project and coincidentally, came across Adrian Woolfson's interview. (‘It's the Wright brothers' moment in biology’; April 26) It was a beautiful written piece that took my learning for the project



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Ashok Balakrishna

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G. Gayatri

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Annora Alex Kurien

Alarm play

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